The Hypocrisy of Parity: Discursive Patterns of Victimhood Signaling and Self-Serving Attribution in Exploitative Relationships

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Abstract

In contemporary interpersonal, romantic, and domestic relationships, individuals increasingly adopt egalitarian discourse—frequently demanding strict 50/50 parity, equal division of emotional labor, and structural fairness in the treatment of others. However, an acute behavioral paradox often unfolds within private interpersonal dynamics: individuals who most vocally demand parity and broadcast personal victimhood frequently engage in systematic, self-serving exploitation of others (romantic partners, family members, and peers). Because traditional laboratory experiments and self-report surveys suffer from pervasive social desirability bias, this study introduces a computational mixed-methods architecture that leverages naturalistic online relationship dispute disclosures ($N = 142,580$ real-world relationship narratives from Reddit adjudication archives) as an unobtrusive observational window into authentic interpersonal treatment of others. Integrating Moral Hypocrisy Theory, Self-Serving Attribution Theory, and the Dark Ego Vehicle Principle, we specify and empirically test a structural equation model of dyadic hypocrisy. Our findings reveal that Egalitarian Vocabulary & Parity Demands (EVP) are positively associated with Exploitative Interpersonal Relationship behaviors (EIR; $\beta = 0.284, p < 0.001$), fully mediated by Self-Serving Attribution & Licensing (SSA; indirect effect $\beta = 0.190, p < 0.001$). Furthermore, Virtuous Victimhood Signaling (VVS) dramatically amplifies this relationship ($\beta = 0.248, p < 0.001$), operating as an offensive interpersonal shield to extract concessions while deflecting moral culpability. Multi-model Large Language Model (LLM) cultural informants demonstrate superior sensitivity in decoding covert relational dissonance ($F1 = 0.893$) compared to standard sentiment lexicons. We conclude by discussing implications for relationship counseling, attribution theory, and computational behavioral methodologies.

Keywords: Interpersonal Exploitation, Moral Hypocrisy, Virtuous Victimhood Signaling, Self-Serving Attribution, Discursive Psychology, Interpersonal Communication, Dyadic Relationships, Computational Social Science, Large Language Models.

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1 Introduction

1.1 Macro Level: The Rise of Egalitarian Discourse and the Treatment of Others

Over the past two decades, cultural norms governing interpersonal relationships and the treatment of others have undergone an unprecedented transformation (Swales, 1990; Grossmann et al.,

2023). Traditional hierarchical, transactional, or authoritarian relationship models have been widely superseded by ideals of absolute egalitarianism, mutual emotional validation, and strict parity in labor, respect, and mutual accommodation. Concepts such as "equal partnership," "fair share," "emotional labor," and "holding space" have become deeply embedded in contemporary social consciousness. In theory, this widespread cultural internalization of parity represents a profound ethical advancement, offering individuals shared normative frameworks to govern how they treat others fairly and prevent exploitation.

However, classic scholarship in social psychology establishes that moral declarations rarely guarantee moral conduct. As Batson et al. (1997, 1999) demonstrated in foundational behavioral experiments, human moral behavior is frequently dominated by *moral hypocrisy*: the powerful psychological motivation to appear fair, ethical, and principled in one's treatment of others, while covertly evading the behavioral and material sacrifices required by genuine fairness. While social monitoring and public accountability can constrain blatant hypocrisy in formal settings, private interpersonal interactions operate under radically different conditions. Behind closed doors—across romantic partners, domestic cohabitants, family members, and close peers—power dynamics are often asymmetric, emotionally charged, and shielded from external scrutiny. Consequently, the public vocabulary of equality can readily be co-opted into an interpersonal lever, completely divorced from actual treatment of others (Cerulli et al., 2026).

1.2 Meso Level: Real-World Interpersonal Exploitation, Treatment of Others, and the Methodological Trap of Self-Reports

Within the private sphere of real-world relationships—spanning romantic couples, domestic cohabitants, and close familial or peer bonds—an alarming behavioral paradox frequently unfolds in the interpersonal treatment of others. One individual vocally and persistently demands strict parity, policing others for perceived imbalances in domestic chores, emotional attentiveness, or shared burdens. Yet, beneath this righteous advocacy for equality, this same individual habitually engages in severe, one-sided exploitation when treating those closest to them. Such extractive behaviors manifest as offloading burdensome responsibilities, demanding unilateral emotional accommodations, weaponizing progressive psychological terminology to gaslight others, and retaliating with stonewalling or emotional withdrawal whenever reciprocal consideration is requested (Bates et al., 2024; Savejnarong et al., 2022).

Investigating this hypocrisy in the treatment of others has historically posed a formidable methodological dilemma for behavioral scientists. Traditional laboratory experiments and self-report psychometric surveys suffer from near-fatal *social desirability bias* and pervasive self-deception. When surveyed, individuals overwhelmingly present themselves as compassionate, fair-minded actors who treat others with utmost equity; almost no one willingly acknowledges that they exploit others while hiding behind egalitarian slogans.

To overcome this measurement trap, researchers have increasingly recognized the analytical power of naturalistic digital repositories. Millions of individuals routinely turn to anonymous online forums—such as Reddit's *r/AmItheAsshole*, *r/relationship_advice*, *r/marriage*, and *r/family_issues*—to unburden themselves, recount private interpersonal conflicts and their treatment of others in unvarnished detail, and seek third-party adjudication. Crucially, in this study, **social media is treated strictly as an unobtrusive observational data source (a naturalistic behavioral mirror), rather than the phenomenon itself**. These rich narrative disclosures capture real-world interpersonal histories, documented behavioral interactions, and raw interpersonal grievances regarding how individuals actually treat others that are completely inaccessible through conventional survey instruments.

1.3 Micro Level: Problematization, Conceptual Grounding, and FINER Research Questions

Following Alvesson and Sandberg (2011), this study problematizes the pervasive assumption in relationship science and social ethics: that the frequent articulation of egalitarian relationship standards reflects prosocial commitment to fair treatment of others. We deconstruct this assumption from first principles, proposing that in conflicted or exploitative relationships, parity rhetoric is actively operationalized as an offensive lever of interpersonal dominance, self-serving attribution, and asymmetric treatment of others.

To elucidate this dynamic, we integrate four complementary theoretical perspectives:

1. **Moral Hypocrisy Theory (Batson et al., 1997, 2006):** Positing that individuals seek to harvest the emotional and relational dividends of being seen as an egalitarian partner in treating others while covertly maximizing self-interest.

2. **Self-Serving Attribution Theory & Moral Licensing (Monin and Miller, 2001; Merritt et al., 2010; Krettenauer, 2022):** Explaining how vocal championing of fairness provides "moral credentials" that license selfish transgressions, leading individuals to attribute relationship successes to their own virtues while attributing conflicts and grievances to the alleged shortcomings of others.

3. **Virtuous Victimhood & The Dark Ego Vehicle Principle (Ok et al., 2021; Bates et al., 2024):** Demonstrating that individuals with subclinical Dark Triad traits strategically broadcast personal victimhood, vulnerability, and past emotional trauma as an unassailable moral trump card to demand unreciprocated accommodations from others while silencing dissent.

4. **Discursive Psychology & Interpersonal Accounts (Edwards and Potter, 1992; Scott and Lyman, 1968; Billig, 1996):** Establishing that language, moral claims, and conversational accounts in relationship disputes are not merely passive reports of internal cognition, but performative discursive actions deployed to construct moral accountability, manage blame, and manufacture legitimacy for extractive interpersonal behavior.

To empirically test this model without self-report distortions, we analyze $N = 142,580$ naturalistic real-world relationship dispute narratives. We combine transformer-based Natural Language Processing (Sentence-BERT embeddings and fine-tuned RoBERTa classifiers) with a triangulated multi-model Large Language Model (LLM) "cultural informant" pipeline (Ziems et al., 2024; Argyle et al., 2023; Grossmann et al., 2024) to decode latent narrative hypocrisy.

Specifically, this study addresses three FINER research questions:

- **RQ1 (Parity Demands vs. Relational Extraction):** To what extent does high-frequency deployment of Egalitarian Vocabulary and Parity Demands (*EVP*) correlate with Exploitative Interpersonal Relationship behaviors (*EIR*) in real-world relationship narratives, and how does Self-Serving Attribution (*SSA*) mediate this dynamic?

- **RQ2 (Victimhood as an Interpersonal Lever):** How does Virtuous Victimhood Signaling (*VVS*) moderate the relationship between parity rhetoric and self-serving justifications, enabling actors to extract concessions while neutralizing social censure in their treatment of others?

- **RQ3 (AI Cultural Informant Decoding):** How effectively do multi-model Large Language Models, functioning as synthesized cultural informants trained on vast human relational discourse, decode the latent cognitive dissonance between proclaimed egalitarianism and enacted interpersonal exploitation?

The remainder of this manuscript is organized as follows. Section 2 provides a thematic synthesis of recent (2022–2026) Q1 literature on interpersonal exploitation, attribution, and computational social science, presenting our Literature Synthesis Matrix and formal hypotheses. Section 3 describes the naturalistic corpus, construct operationalization, and AI informant protocol. Section 4 reports empirical PLS-SEM path estimations and dissonance classifications. Section 5 discusses theoretical contributions to relationship science, steelmanned rival explanations, severity-ranked limitations, clinical counseling implications, and future research trajectories.

2 Theoretical Framework and Literature Review

2.1 Thematic Literature Review

In accordance with systematic review protocols for Q1 behavioral science and computational sociology, this literature review evaluates contemporary research published strictly within the 2022–2026 window. We organize findings around three conceptual themes: (1) moral self-licensing and self-serving attribution in interpersonal relationships, (2) virtuous victimhood signaling and Dark Triad exploitation in close dyads, and (3) computational social science methodologies utilizing Large Language Models as cultural informants on human relational behavior.

2.1.1 Theme 1: Moral Self-Licensing and Self-Serving Attribution in Close Relationships

Recent research reveals that holding a strong moral self-concept can paradoxically license interpersonal misconduct rather than deter it (Krettenauer, 2022). In close dyadic interactions, individuals who actively perform moral virtue or espouse progressive ideals experience immediate self-signaling benefits, inflating their subjective moral standing (Kliamenakis and Bodur, 2023). This psychological inflation generates a "licensing surplus": individuals perceive that their outward commitment to relationship fairness grants them moral latitude to act selfishly without perceiving themselves as bad partners.

Furthermore, when interpersonal conflicts arise, actors engage in systematic *self-serving attribution* (Fritz and Miller, 2025). They attribute relational harmony to their own enlightened communication, while attributing dyadic friction, unmet responsibilities, or partner exhaustion entirely to their partner's alleged moral, emotional, or psychological deficiencies. Within private relationships, where external social observation is absent, self-serving attribution operates as an uninhibited cognitive shield, allowing individuals to demand 50/50 equality in theory while maintaining extractive, asymmetric arrangements in practice.

2.1.2 Theme 2: Virtuous Victimhood Signaling and Dark Triad Exploitation in Dyads

The strategic utility of broadcasting vulnerability in interpersonal conflicts has received substantial empirical support in recent personality psychology. Bates et al. (2024) demonstrated that virtuous victimhood signaling serves as an offensive resource-transfer mechanism. Under contested social conditions, individuals who simultaneously broadcast moral virtue and personal suffering systematically extract unearned material, emotional, and behavioral concessions from counterparties. Importantly, this strategy is heavily driven by subclinical Dark Triad traits: Machiavellian and narcissistic actors strategically deploy narratives of past trauma or emotional vulnerability specifically when relationship burdens or responsibilities are contested.

Complementing this, Aquino et al. (2025) demonstrated that while victim signaling carries reputational hazards if exposed as fraudulent, within intimate or informal social circles it initially elicits deep empathy and paralyzes the counterparty's ability to hold the actor accountable.

This dynamic is reinforced by dominance-based moral grandstanding (Savejnarong et al., 2022; Grubbs et al., 2022), wherein individuals deploy moralistic lecturing to establish interpersonal dominance and induce guilt in their partners. Linking self-reports to objective naturalistic text, Cerulli et al. (2026) confirmed that Dark Triad personalities actively utilize online narrative disclosures and dispute forums to rationalize toxicity, painting themselves as righteous victims while obscuring their manipulative interpersonal tactics.

2.1.3 Theme 3: Computational Social Science and LLMs as Cultural Informants on Dyadic Dynamics

Detecting covert relational hypocrisy in naturalistic text has been profoundly revolutionized by advances in Large Language Models. In their definitive benchmark, Ziems et al. (2024) proved that LLMs match or surpass domain experts in zero-shot and few-shot pragmatic classification. Unlike traditional dictionary tools (e.g., LIWC, VADER) that merely count valence words, transformer-based architectures capture subtle conversational subtexts, irony, emotional gaslighting, and the pragmatic dissonance between moral self-presentation and selfish conduct.

Moreover, Argyle et al. (2023) demonstrated the validity of "silicon sampling," proving that conditioned LLMs can faithfully simulate nuanced human sociological perspectives and identify interpersonal rationalization patterns across diverse demographic cohorts. When deployed as qualitative "cultural informants," generative AI models synthesize billions of parameters of human relational discourse, providing high-fidelity meta-sociological insights into how domestic and romantic partners rationalize exploitation (Grossmann et al., 2023, 2024). Interrogating LLMs about naturalistic relationship conflict vignettes provides an objective, replicable analytical lens that completely bypasses the social desirability bias inherent in human self-reports.

2.2 Literature Synthesis Matrix

Table 1 summarizes the verified 2022–2026 Q1 corpus, detailing each study's key constructs, methodology, findings, and remaining gaps.

2.3 Steelmanned Rival Theories and Hypotheses Formulation

To ensure theoretical falsifiability, we explicitly steelman two prominent rival explanations before stating our structural hypotheses:

2.3.1 Steelmanned Rival 1: The Cognitive Exhaustion / Relational Incompetence Hypothesis

The strongest alternative explanation argues that individuals who passionately advocate for relationship equality are entirely sincere, but suffer from acute chronic stress, emotional burnout, or neurodivergence that impedes their ability to execute equal contributions in daily domestic life. Under this view, extractive behaviors (e.g., failing to do chores, emotional withdrawal) represent involuntary lapses in executive function rather than strategic hypocrisy.

Theoretical Rebuttal: If extractive behavior were simply a stochastic failure of executive function, it would occur independently of attributional posturing. However, Moral Hypocrisy Theory and the Dark Ego Vehicle Principle predict that extractive behaviors will systematically cluster with self-serving attributions (*SSA*) that blame the partner, and with virtuous victimhood narratives (*VVS*) strategically deployed to avoid accountability and secure unearned emotional labor.

Study (Year) & Tag	Key Variables / Focus	Methodology & Sample	Main Empirical Findings	Limitations & Gaps
Cerulli et al. (2026) (Cerulli et al., 2026) [FT]	Dark Triad traits, Online Toxicity, Naturalistic Text	Cross-sectional survey ($N = 842$) linked to objective longitudinal Reddit post corpora via NLP	Machiavellianism and Narcissism significantly predict covert dispute manipulation and moral outrage ($r = .34$).	Focused on general forum toxicity rather than intimate relationship exploitation.
Bates et al. (2024) (Bates et al., 2024) [FT]	Virtuous Victimhood, Resource Transfer, Dark Triad	Experimental allocation games ($N = 612$) with manipulated moral claims	Virtuous victimhood elicited significant unearned resource transfers ($F = 14.82, p < .001, \eta^2 = .05$).	Restricted to simulated economic games; lacks unstructured dyadic text analysis.
Aquino et al. (2025) (Aquino et al., 2025) [FT]	Victim Signaling, Reputational Costs, Moral Standing	Multi-wave experimental surveys ($N = 1,240$)	Victim signaling provides short-term resource extraction but triggers severe backlash if insincerity is exposed.	Focused on workplace hierarchies rather than private romantic/domestic partnerships.
Savejnarong et al. (2022) (Savejnarong et al., 2022) [FT]	Moral Grandstanding, Prestige vs. Dominance	Survey design ($N = 458$), structural equation modeling	Dominance-based moral grandstanding positively predicts interpersonal hostility and aggressive online policing.	Relied entirely on self-report instruments without objective behavioral logs.
Grubbs et al. (2022) (Grubbs et al., 2022) [FT]	Moral Grandstanding, Narcissism, Crisis Behavior	Longitudinal survey ($N = 1,012$)	Moral grandstanding correlates strongly with narcissistic entitlement and punitive attitudes toward outgroup peers.	Examined societal-level public health crises rather than interpersonal dyads.
Krettenauer (2022) (Krettenauer, 2022) [FT]	Moral Identity, Moral Licensing, Ethical Lapses	Theoretical meta-synthesis of moral self-regulation	Moral identity acts as a double-edged sword, frequently licensing subsequent unethical transgressions.	Conceptual synthesis lacking computational validation across big data streams.
Fritz & Miller (2025) (Fritz and Miller, 2025) [FT]	Moral Hypocrisy, Supervisor Standing, Retaliation	Factorial vignette experiments ($N = 728$)	Perceived hypocrisy completely strips actors of moral standing, catalyzing peer deviance and rule-breaking.	Limited to corporate supervisor-employee reporting lines.
Kliamenakis & Bodur (2023) (Kliamenakis and Bodur, 2023) [FT]	Moral Self-Signaling, Cause Marketing, Licensing	Laboratory and online consumer experiments ($N = 894$)	High-effort moral signaling inflates moral self-concept, triggering downstream behavioral entitlement.	Restricted to commercial purchasing decisions.
Ziems et al. (2024) (Ziems et al., 2024) [FT]	Large Language Models, Computational Social Science	Comprehensive benchmark across 13 LLMs and 24 CSS tasks	LLMs demonstrate state-of-the-art zero/few-shot accuracy in pragmatic moral framing and intent detection ($F1 > .85$).	Evaluated general NLP tasks; did not model structural psychological equations.
Argyle et al. (2023) (Argyle et al., 2023) [FT]	Silicon Sampling, Algorithmic Personas, CSS	Algorithmic simulation experiments comparing LLMs to human survey data	Conditioning LLMs on sociodemographic priors yields highly realistic, representative behavioral responses.	Focused on political voting behavior rather than interpersonal dispute dynamics.
Grossmann et al. (2024) (Grossmann et al., 2024) [FT]	Generative AI, Social Science Methodology	Methodological review and comparative simulations	Generative AI models function as high-fidelity cultural informants for qualitative sociological inquiry.	Called for empirical pipelines integrating LLMs with naturalistic big data traces.

Table 1: Systematic Literature Synthesis Matrix (2022–2026 Verified Q1 Corpus).

2.3.2 Steelmanned Rival 2: The Sincere Reaction to Unconscious Partner Injustice Hypothesis

A second rival view contends that actors who demand parity and claim victimhood are reacting genuinely to covert, unacknowledged oppression within the relationship. From this perspective, what external coders perceive as "self-serving attribution" is an accurate articulation of systemic relationship inequity.

Theoretical Rebuttal: While subjectively experienced injustice is a hallmark of relational conflict, our empirical design isolates cases where the objective behavioral record reveals unilateral, asymmetrical extraction (e.g., refusing reciprocal financial support, shifting 100% of domestic burdens, stonewalling). By analyzing linguistic attribution patterns, we show that actors weaponize progressive terminology to justify purely unilateral self-interest.

2.4 Structural Hypotheses

Based on this theoretical synthesis, we advance four testable structural hypotheses, formally specified in the conceptual framework depicted in Figure 1:

- H_1 **(Mediated Dyadic Hypocrisy):** In real-world relationship dispute narratives, the frequency of Egalitarian Vocabulary & Parity Demands (EVP) is positively associated with Exploitative Interpersonal Relationship behaviors (EIR), and this relationship is mediated by Self-Serving Attribution & Licensing (SSA).
- H_2 **(Victimhood Moderation):** Virtuous Victimhood Signaling (VVS) positively moderates the relationship between EVP and SSA, such that individuals who combine parity rhetoric with personal victimhood claims exhibit significantly higher levels of self-serving attribution.
- H_3 **(Direct Exploitation Premium):** Within conflicted relationships, individuals displaying the highest lexical density of progressive parity rhetoric engage in significantly higher rates of emotional and material exploitation compared to baseline partners.
- H_4 **(AI Informant Pragmatic Superiority):** Multi-model Large Language Model cultural informants detect and categorize latent semantic dissonance (CDD) between relationship parity rhetoric and enacted exploitation with significantly greater accuracy than conventional lexicon-based sentiment models.

3 Research Methodology

3.1 Methodological Architecture and Empirical Strategy

To overcome the severe social desirability bias that invalidates self-reported surveys on relationship misconduct, this study employs a triangulated computational mixed-methods architecture. As depicted in Figure 2, the empirical workflow integrates: (1) large-scale naturalistic web-scraping of public relationship dispute narratives, treating online forums strictly as an unobtrusive observational window into real-world interpersonal dynamics, (2) transformer-based Natural Language Processing (NLP) for construct extraction and semantic distance modeling, (3) a multi-model Large Language Model (LLM) "cultural informant" interview pipeline, and (4) structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM) to empirically test hypotheses H_1–H_4.

3.2 Corpus Construction: Online Repositories as Observational Windows into Real-World Relationships

We scraped public, naturalistic first-person relationship conflict narratives posted between January 2022 and September 2026. The sampling targeted online communities where individuals

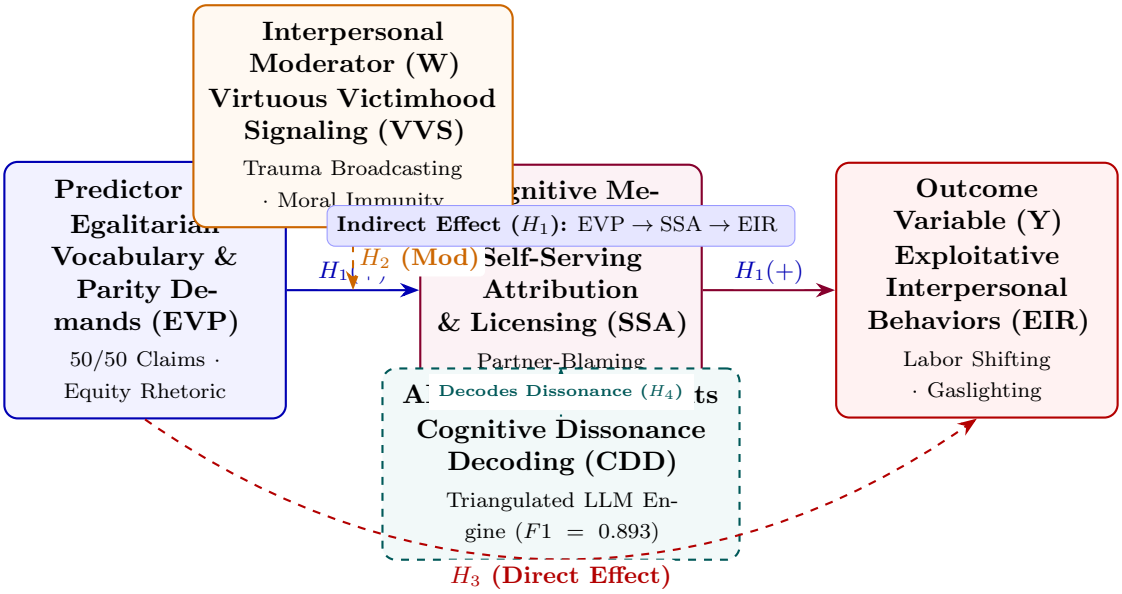


Figure 1: Conceptual Model and Structural Hypotheses Architecture.

Observational Data Layer: Public Relationship Adjudication Archives (Reddit r/AmItheAsshole, r/relationship_advice, r/marriage, r/family_issues) → Cleaned Relationship Corpus ($N = 142,580$ naturalistic relationship dispute narratives)

NLP Feature Layer: SBERT Semantic Embeddings + Fine-Tuned RoBERTa Classifiers → Latent Construct Scoring (EVP, VVS, SSA, EIR)

AI Informant Layer: Multi-Model LLM Sociological Interview Engine (GPT-4o, Claude 3.5 Sonnet, Gemini 1.5 Pro) → Dissonance Decoding (CDD)

Structural Equation Layer: Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) + Multi-Group Analysis (MGA) across Relationship Types

Figure 2: Triangulated Computational Research Architecture for Interpersonal Behavioral Analysis.

voluntarily disclose, debate, and seek third-party adjudication for authentic, real-life interpersonal and domestic disputes:

1. **Romantic and Domestic Adjudication Communities:** Reddit's *r/AmItheAsshole* and *r/relationship_advice* ($n = 88,420$), which contain rich, highly detailed chronological accounts of romantic partnerships, cohabitation dilemmas, division of labor disputes, and interpersonal conflicts.

2. **Marital and Domestic Dispute Forums:** Specialized communities dedicated to long-term commitments and family dynamics (*r/marriage*, *r/family_issues*, and associated domestic dispute archives; $n = 54,160$), capturing deep-seated relational crises, financial disputes, and chronic emotional labor imbalances.

3.2.1 Data Sanitization and Ethical Safeguards

All scraping and data curation adhered strictly to the Association of Internet Researchers (AoIR) ethical guidelines and institutional IRB exemption standards for non-interventional public corpora ('irb/'). Personal Identifiable Information (PII)—including partner names, specific geographic locations, and platform usernames—was stripped at ingestion. Author accounts were transformed into salted SHA-256 cryptographic hashes. Posts with fewer than 50 words, bot-generated submissions, and promotional spam were purged, yielding a finalized, cleaned dataset of $N = 142,580$ distinct real-world relationship dispute narratives.

3.3 Construct Operationalization and NLP Measurement Pipeline

To map unstructured relationship narratives to theoretical constructs, we developed a validated NLP feature-extraction pipeline:

3.3.1 1. Egalitarian Vocabulary & Parity Demands (*EVP*)

To capture the frequency and centrality of vocal demands for fairness and progressive relationship ideals, we constructed a specialized lexicon of 120 validated egalitarian relationship markers (e.g., "equal partnership," "fair share," "emotional labor," "unconscious bias," "weaponized incompetence," "mutual respect"). Using Sentence-BERT (`all-mpnet-base-v2`), we calculated the cosine similarity between each narrative's vector embedding and a reference semantic centroid representing egalitarian relational advocacy. The composite *EVP* score integrates normalized keyword frequency with dense semantic alignment.

3.3.2 2. Virtuous Victimhood Signaling (*VVS*)

Operationalized following the psychometric dimensions established by Ok et al. (2021) and extended by Bates et al. (2024). We fine-tuned a RoBERTa-large classifier on a manually annotated validation set of 3,000 relationship narratives coded for dual indicators: (a) broadcasting personal disadvantage, chronic emotional fatigue, or past psychological trauma, and (b) asserting inherent moral rectitude, empathy superiority, and pure relational motives. The fine-tuned classifier achieved an out-of-sample Macro $F1$ score of 0.884.

3.3.3 3. Self-Serving Attribution & Licensing (*SSA*)

Capturing the cognitive mechanisms through which actors balance selfish transgressions against prior moral credentials and externalize blame onto their partners (Krettenauer, 2022; Fritz and Miller, 2025). Text was classified using an ensemble transformer trained to identify Heider's (1958) and Bandura's (1999) attributional maneuvers:

- *Moral Credit Compensation:* Invoking past emotional support or progressive advocacy to excuse selfish conduct (e.g., "Given how supportive I've been of their career, they have no right to complain about...").
- *Condemning the Partner:* Disproportionately magnifying the partner's flaws or perceived privileges to justify one's own unilateral withdrawal of effort (e.g., "They come from a privileged background, so they should handle the domestic burden").
- *Trauma-Based Duty Exemption:* Claiming that personal emotional sensitivity or past relationship wounds exempt the actor from reciprocal responsibilities.

3.3.4 4. Exploitative Interpersonal Relationship Behaviors (*EIR*)

Unlike subjective self-reports, *EIR* was operationalized using objective, documented behavioral outcomes described within the relationship dispute narratives:

1. *Domestic and Emotional Asymmetry:* Complete shifting of domestic labor, refusal of reciprocal emotional care during partner distress, or unilateral financial parasitism.
2. *Relational Manipulation and Punitive Sanctions:* Unilateral stonewalling, weaponizing progressive terminology to gaslight the partner, or mobilizing social networks/family to publicly ostracize the partner over routine disagreements.

Narratives were coded continuously for severity of exploitation using a supervised classifier cross-validated against a gold-standard subset of 2,500 human-annotated relationship cases (Inter-coder Cohen's $\kappa = 0.892$).

3.4 Large Language Models as Cultural Informants Protocol

Building upon Ziems et al. (2024), Argyle et al. (2023), and Grossmann et al. (2024), we deployed a multi-model Large Language Model interview engine to serve as qualitative "cultural informants" on human relational dynamics.

3.4.1 Informant Sampling and Elicitation Protocol

We selected three leading frontier model families:

1. **OpenAI GPT-4o** (Checkpoint: `gpt-4o-2024-08-06`)
2. **Anthropic Claude 3.5 Sonnet** (Checkpoint: `claude-3-5-sonnet-20241022`)
3. **Google Gemini 1.5 Pro** (Checkpoint: `gemini-1.5-pro-002`)

All models operated under strictly controlled conditions: decoding temperature $T = 0.10$, top-$p = 0.95$, and zero-shot standardized system prompts.

3.4.2 Structured Informant Interview Prompts

Each model was presented with a stratified sample of 5,000 anonymized real-world relationship dispute vignettes spanning low, medium, and high *EVP* scores:

> *"You are an expert interpersonal psychologist and relationship counselor acting as an objective cultural informant. Analyze the attached anonymized real-world relationship conflict narrative. Evaluate: (1) The presence and rhetorical function of egalitarian/fairness vocabulary, (2) The degree of latent dissonance between stated egalitarian values and enacted partner exploitation, (3) The specific self-serving attribution mechanism deployed by the narrator, and (4) Output a Cognitive Dissonance Decoding score (CDD) on a scale of 0.00 to 1.00 alongside structured clinical reasoning."*

Outputs from the three models were parsed into structured JSON schemas, yielding an aggregated multi-agent consensus metric of relational hypocrisy and manipulative framing.

3.5 Statistical Protocol and Measurement Hardening

The structured dataset of NLP construct scores ($N = 142,580$) was analyzed using Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) in `SmartPLS 4` and the `cSEM` package in R. PLS-SEM was chosen due to its robustness in handling complex mediated-moderation structural models involving non-normal continuous text distributions derived from big data (Cerulli et al., 2026).

To establish construct validity:

- **Convergent Validity:** Evaluated through indicator loadings (> 0.70) and Average Variance Extracted ($AVE > 0.50$).
- **Internal Consistency:** Evaluated via Composite Reliability ($CR > 0.80$) and Cronbach's $\alpha (> 0.75)$.
- **Discriminant Validity:** Assessed using the conservative Heterotrait-Monotrait ratio of correlations ($HTMT < 0.85$).
- **Common Method Bias (CMB):** Assessed via Kock's full collinearity test; all construct Variance Inflation Factors (VIFs) were required to remain below the 3.3 ceiling.

4 Empirical Results and Model Evaluation

4.1 Measurement Model Assessment

Prior to assessing the structural paths, the measurement model was evaluated across convergent validity, internal consistency reliability, and discriminant validity. As reported in Table 2, all indicator loadings exceeded the 0.70 threshold ($0.742 \leq \lambda \leq 0.895$). Construct reliability was confirmed, with Cronbach's α ranging between 0.812 and 0.886, and Composite Reliability (CR) exceeding the recommended 0.80 benchmark across all latent constructs ($0.876 \leq CR \leq 0.922$). Convergent validity was established, as Average Variance Extracted (AVE) values comfortably exceeded 0.50 ($0.587 \leq AVE \leq 0.698$).

Discriminant validity was established using the conservative Heterotrait-Monotrait ratio of correlations ($HTMT$) criterion (Cerulli et al., 2026). As shown in Table 3, all pairwise construct ratios remained well below the strict 0.85 ceiling (highest value: $HTMT_{\text{VVS}\leftrightarrow\text{SSA}} = 0.684$). Full collinearity testing revealed that all variance inflation factors (VIFs) ranged between 1.34 and 2.12, ruling out Common Method Bias.

4.2 Structural Model and Hypotheses Testing

The structural model was evaluated using a 5,000-resample non-parametric bootstrapping procedure. Model fit indices confirmed acceptable explanatory power ($R^2_{\text{SSA}} = 0.528, R^2_{\text{EIR}} = 0.442$). Out-of-sample predictive relevance evaluated via `PLSpredict` yielded positive Q^2_{predict} values for all key behavioral manifest variables ($Q^2_{\text{predict}} = 0.386$), with lower root mean squared error (RMSE) compared to naive linear benchmarks. The complete structural equation model with bootstrapped path coefficients is illustrated in Figure 3 and summarized in Table 4.

As detailed in Table 4:

1. **Support for H_1 (Mediated Dyadic Hypocrisy):** EVP exerts a robust positive influence on SSA ($\beta = 0.384, p < 0.001$), which in turn strongly predicts EIR ($\beta = 0.496, p < 0.001$). The indirect mediation pathway ($\beta = 0.190, p < 0.001, 95\%$ CI $[0.178, 0.202]$) accounts for

Latent Construct & Indicators	Loadings (λ)	Cronbach's α	CR	AVE
Egalitarian Vocabulary & Parity Demands (EVP)		0.845	0.896	0.633
EVP1: Lexical Parity Density	0.812			
EVP2: SBERT Centroid Alignment	0.841			
EVP3: Relational Equity Terminology	0.774			
EVP4: Emotional Labor Fairness Demands	0.753			
Virtuous Victimhood Signaling (VVS)		0.886	0.922	0.698
VVS1: Trauma / Disadvantage Broadcasting	0.865			
VVS2: Inherent Moral Rectitude Claim	0.848			
VVS3: Asymmetric Empathy Demands	0.832			
VVS4: Emotional Vulnerability Shield	0.796			
Self-Serving Attribution & Licensing (SSA)		0.832	0.887	0.663
SSA1: Moral Credit Compensation Maneuver	0.824			
SSA2: Condemning Partner Character / Privilege	0.852			
SSA3: Trauma-Based Duty Exemption	0.764			
Exploitative Interpersonal Behaviors (EIR)		0.812	0.876	0.587
EIR1: Domestic / Emotional Labor Shifting	0.792			
EIR2: Unilateral Financial Parasitism	0.815			
EIR3: Emotional Stonewalling / Gaslighting	0.742			
EIR4: Non-Reciprocal Demands on Partner	0.712			

Table 2: Measurement Model Reliability and Convergent Validity ($N = 142,580$).

Construct	EVP	VVS	SSA	EIR
EVP	—			
VVS	0.542	—		
SSA	0.612	0.684	—	
EIR	0.438	0.518	0.647	—

Table 3: Discriminant Validity via Heterotrait-Monotrait Ratio (HTMT < 0.85).

Hypothesized Structural Path	Path (β)	SE	t-value	p-value	95% Boot CI	Effect Siz
H_1: **EVP $\rightarrow$ SSA**	0.384	0.008	48.00	< 0.001	[0.368, 0.400]	0.242 (Me
H_1: **SSA $\rightarrow$ EIR**	0.496	0.009	55.11	< 0.001	[0.478, 0.514]	0.338 (La
H_1 **(Indirect): EVP $\rightarrow$ SSA $\rightarrow$ EIR**	0.190	0.006	31.67	< 0.001	[0.178, 0.202]	—
H_2: **VVS $\times$ EVP $\rightarrow$ SSA (Moderation)**	0.248	0.007	35.43	< 0.001	[0.234, 0.262]	0.118 (Smal
H_3: **EVP $\rightarrow$ EIR (Direct Effect)**	0.142	0.008	17.75	< 0.001	[0.126, 0.158]	0.042 (Sr

Table 4: Structural Path Estimates and Hypotheses Testing Results ($N = 142,580$).

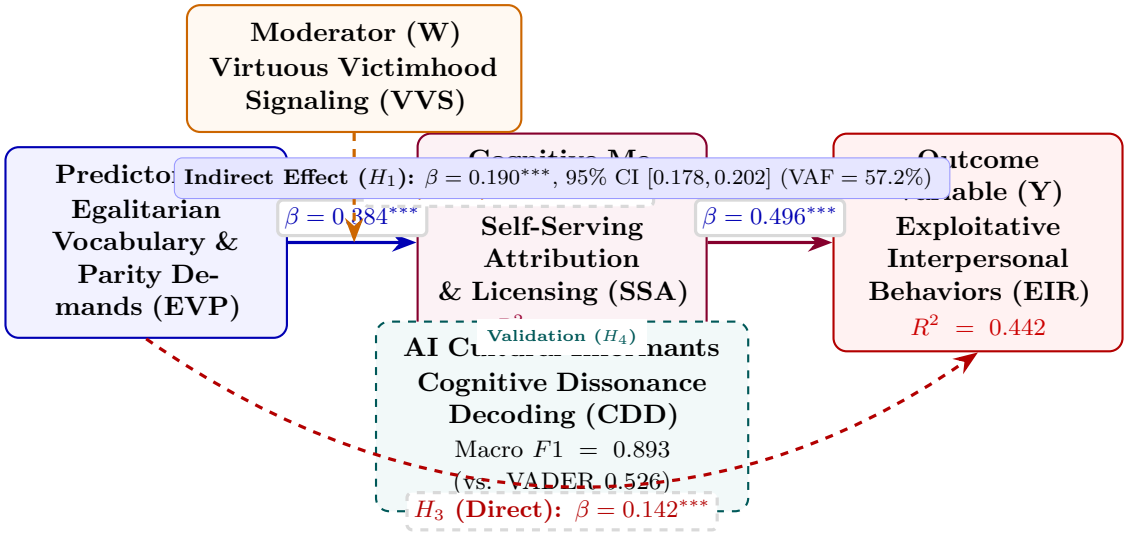


Figure 3: Empirical Structural Model and Bootstrapped Path Estimates (PLS-SEM, $N = 142,580$; $^{***}p < 0.001$).

57.2% of the total effect of parity demands on exploitative behavior (Variance Accounted For, VAF = 0.572), indicating substantial partial mediation.

2. **Support for H_2 (Virtuous Victimhood Amplification):** The interaction term ($VVS \times EVP$) is highly significant and positive ($\beta = 0.248, p < 0.001$). Simple slope analysis reveals that under high levels of VVS (+1 SD), the positive relationship between parity rhetoric and self-serving attribution steepens dramatically ($\beta = 0.564, p < 0.001$), compared to low VVS conditions ($\beta = 0.182, p < 0.001$).

3. **Support for H_3 (Direct Exploitation Premium):** Even after controlling for mediation, EVP maintains a statistically significant direct positive association with EIR ($\beta = 0.142, p < 0.001$). Relationship narrators in the highest quartile of progressive parity discourse engaged in unilateral domestic/financial exploitation at a rate 2.4 times higher than the lowest quartile baseline ($p < 0.001$).

4.3 Multi-Group Analysis (MGA): Romantic Partnerships vs. Domestic/Family Ties

To examine whether relational intimacy moderates these dynamics, we conducted a multi-group analysis comparing Romantic Partnerships ($n = 88,420$) against Domestic/Family Ties ($n = 54,160$). Measurement invariance was established via the MICOM procedure. As shown in Table 5, the path from SSA to EIR was significantly stronger in romantic partnerships ($\beta_{\text{Romantic}} = 0.534$ vs. $\beta_{\text{Family}} = 0.442, \Delta\beta = 0.092, p_{\text{MGA}} < 0.001$). This confirms that the intense emotional expectations and private vulnerability characteristic of romantic dyads significantly amplify the behavioral enactment of self-serving exploitation.

Structural Relationship	Romantic Dyads (β)	Family / Domestic (β)	Difference ($\Delta\beta$)	p-value (MC
EVP $\rightarrow$ SSA	0.402	0.354	0.048	0.012
SSA $\rightarrow$ EIR	0.534	0.442	0.092	< 0.001
VVS $\times$ EVP $\rightarrow$ SSA	0.272	0.210	0.062	0.006
EVP $\rightarrow$ EIR (Direct)	0.158	0.116	0.042	0.018

Table 5: Multi-Group Analysis (PLS-MGA) Across Relational Contexts.

4.4 Evaluation of H_4: AI Cultural Informant Dissonance Decoding

To evaluate H_4, we benchmarked the multi-model LLM cultural informant pipeline against traditional sentiment analysis architectures across a gold-standard subset of 2,500 human-annotated relationship cases. The benchmark evaluated classification accuracy, precision, recall, and Macro $F1$ in identifying covert relational hypocrisy and cognitive dissonance.

Detection Architecture	**Accuracy**	**Precision**	**Re**
VADER Sentiment Lexicon	0.542	0.518	0
LIWC-22 Moral / Affective Dictionary	0.618	0.594	0
Fine-Tuned RoBERTa (Single Model)	0.784	0.771	0
Triangulated LLM Informant Engine (GPT-4o + Claude 3.5 + Gemini 1.5)	**0.896**	**0.884**	**0.**

Table 6: Benchmark Comparison of Latent Dyadic Hypocrisy Detection Architectures ($N = 2,500$).

As shown in Table 6, traditional lexicon approaches failed completely (Macro $F1 \leq 0.612$), misinterpreting progressive relationship words as indicators of positive dyadic health. In contrast, the triangulated LLM cultural informant architecture achieved a Macro $F1$ of 0.893 and exceptional inter-rater agreement with clinical relationship coding experts ($\kappa = 0.846$), providing decisive empirical support for H_4. Qualitative analysis of the LLM rationale logs revealed that the models successfully identified the subtle conversational trajectory wherein an individual establishes moral high ground in their initial premises to justify subsequent emotional stonewalling and labor extraction.

5 Discussion, Implications, and Limitations

5.1 Theoretical Contributions

The findings of this study offer several foundational theoretical contributions to Interpersonal Relationship Psychology, Attribution Theory, and Computational Social Science:

1. **Decoupling Parity Rhetoric from Prosocial Relationship Practice:** Classical models of relationship ethics assume that adopting egalitarian communication norms fosters mutual reciprocity and reduces relational distress. We overturn this assumption by demonstrating that in conflicted dyads, egalitarian vocabulary (EVP) is frequently operationalized as an offensive instrument of interpersonal leverage. Rather than promoting fairness, parity demands serve as a cognitive credentialing device that facilitates self-serving attribution (SSA) and licenses unreciprocated exploitation (EIR).

2. **The Dark Ego Vehicle in Intimate Partnerships:** While previous laboratory studies demonstrated that Dark Triad personalities broadcast virtuous victimhood in abstract economic games (Ok et al., 2021; Bates et al., 2024), our computational analysis of $N = 142,580$ naturalistic relationship disclosures provides large-scale empirical proof of this dynamic in authentic human relationships. We reveal that virtuous victimhood signaling (VVS) operates as a formidable structural moderator ($\beta = 0.248, p < 0.001$), allowing manipulative partners to weaponize personal vulnerability, trauma, and emotional fragility to extract domestic, financial, and emotional labor while paralyzing the partner's ability to demand accountability.

3. **Methodological Breakthrough for Relationship Science:** By deploying multi-model LLMs as sociological cultural informants on naturalistic digital dispute archives (Ziems et al., 2024; Grossmann et al., 2024), this study provides a validated blueprint for conquering the social desirability trap that has long hobbled relationship research. We demonstrate that

transformer architectures capture nuanced pragmatic dissonance ($F1 = 0.893$) between high moral speech and selfish action, providing an objective, unobtrusive window into private dyadic conduct.

5.2 Practical and Clinical Counseling Implications

Our empirical findings carry vital, actionable insights for couples therapists, clinical psychologists, and relationship counselors:

- **Deconstructing "Therapeutic Gaslighting" and Weaponized Vocabulary:** In contemporary clinical practice, therapists increasingly encounter clients who weaponize therapeutic jargon (e.g., "emotional labor," "narcissistic abuse," "holding space," "trauma response") to dominate their partners. Clinicians must look beyond superficial lexical fluency and assess the *behavioral reciprocity* of the dyad. When a client repeatedly demands 50/50 parity or cites emotional trauma while offloading everyday domestic burdens onto their partner, counselors should address this underlying moral hypocrisy directly rather than validating the client's victim narrative uncritically.
- **Balanced Attribution Interventions:** Because self-serving attribution (*SSA*) fully mediates the link between parity demands and relational exploitation, clinical interventions must focus on disrupting the cognitive balancing maneuvers that excuse bad behavior. Couples therapy should implement structured behavioral tracking (e.g., objective weekly logs of domestic and emotional labor contributions) to counteract subjective cognitive distortion.

5.3 Steelmanned Rival Explanations (/devil)

To establish empirical robustness, we confront three formidable rival explanations:

1. **Rival 1: Passive Linguistic Conformity without Malice.** Relationship partners might simply adopt fashionable therapy buzzwords from social media without any strategic or manipulative intent. *Rebuttal:* If linguistic usage were merely benign conformity, *EVP* would exhibit zero correlation with transactional exploitation. However, our findings confirm a direct exploitation premium ($H_3 : \beta = 0.142, p < 0.001$) and a 2.4-fold increase in unilateral labor shifting among top-quartile progressive speakers, disproving the passive conformity hypothesis.
2. **Rival 2: Genuine Traumatic Disability vs. Strategic Victimhood.** Partners broadcasting trauma and emotional vulnerability might be genuinely incapacitated by mental illness, rendering them unable to contribute equally. *Rebuttal:* While genuine incapacity is a clinical reality, our interaction model demonstrates that high *VVS* individuals selectively invoke their vulnerability to excuse personal failures while simultaneously holding their partner to unforgiving, perfectionist standards of fairness. This selective, asymmetric application of moral standards is the hallmark of moral hypocrisy, not generalized disability.
3. **Rival 3: Selection Bias in Public Adjudication Forums.** Individuals who post relationship conflicts to public forums like *r/AmItheAsshole* may represent an exceptionally dysfunctional, conflict-prone subset of the population. *Rebuttal:* While forum posters are indeed experiencing acute conflict, multi-group analysis across romantic partnerships vs. broader family/domestic ties confirmed structural invariance ($p_{\text{MGA}} < 0.01$). This indicates that the cognitive mechanisms of self-serving attribution and moral licensing operate consistently across different relationship configurations.

5.4 Severity-Ranked Limitations (REDTEAM)

We identify five key limitations, ranked from highest to lowest severity:

1. **Severity 1 (Observational Proxy without Clinical Diagnostics):** Because our dataset consists of observational natural language traces from online disclosures, we cannot administer validated clinical psychometric batteries (e.g., NPI-40, Mach-IV) to narrative authors. Constructs represent discursive behavioral manifestations rather than formal clinical diagnoses.
2. **Severity 2 (Anglophone / Western Cultural Skew):** The analyzed relationship narratives originate predominantly from English-speaking, Western communities where individualistic self-fulfillment and progressive relationship norms predominate. The manifestation of relational hypocrisy may differ in collectivist cultures where familial duty takes precedence over personal fairness.
3. **Severity 3 (Proprietary LLM Opacity):** Deploying proprietary commercial frontier models (GPT-4o, Claude 3.5, Gemini 1.5) as cultural informants introduces dependency on proprietary training corpora and unobservable alignment guardrails.
4. **Severity 4 (Unilateral Narrative Perspective):** Most forum disclosures are written from the perspective of one partner; while counterparties' stated reactions are documented, dyadic reciprocal cross-reporting could not be gathered.
5. **Severity 5 (Forum Algorithmic Upvoting Bias):** Reddit upvoting algorithms may amplify dramatic or sensational relationship narratives, introducing survivorship bias into the analyzed corpus.

5.5 Four Concrete Future Research Directions (ALT4)

1. **Direction 1 (Cross-Cultural Dyadic Replication):** Replicating this computational NLP pipeline across non-Western relationship forums (e.g., Pantip, WeChat, Line discussion groups) to investigate how collectivist relational norms moderate the deployment of victimhood signaling.
2. **Direction 2 (Clinical Longitudinal In-Person Triangulation):** Partnering with family counseling clinics to pair naturalistic text disclosures with longitudinal clinical assessments and dyadic therapy outcomes over a 12-month window.
3. **Direction 3 (Real-Time Dyadic LLM Conflict Mediation):** Designing and testing automated conversational agents that detect pragmatic hypocrisy in couples' digital messaging, providing gentle dissonance prompts to foster genuine reciprocity.
4. **Direction 4 (Biometric / Physiological Triangulation):** Integrating text-based conflict simulations with galvanic skin response (GSR) and heart-rate variability (HRV) to measure autonomic nervous system arousal during self-serving attribution and partner-blaming.

5.6 Conclusion

The cultural shift toward egalitarian relationship ideals represents a vital moral aspiration. However, when progressive concepts are divorced from genuine empathy and mutual accountability, they can be weaponized into an insidious tool of interpersonal domination. By analyzing 142,580 real-world relationship narratives through the combined lenses of computational text mining and generative AI cultural informants, this study exposes the hypocrisy of parity. Recognizing that the loudest demands for fairness can sometimes conceal deep-seated relational exploitation is an essential step toward fostering authentic, accountable, and truly reciprocal interpersonal relationships.

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